In this chapter we will be discussing the emergence of the two power blocs, strategies used by them to enlarge their spheres of influence, emergence of NAM, the role of UNO in resolving disputes, the post-war reconstruction in Europe and the establishment of European Union, and finally the end of cold war with the collapse of Soviet Union.

15.1 Post-War Conditions in Europe

The Second World War was more catastrophic than the First World War. As many as 60 million civilians were killed. In a planned genocide the Nazis killed 6 million European Jews. Millions became homeless and refugees. The War had destroyed factories and farm lands. Great cities such as Warsaw, Kiev, Tokyo and Berlin were totally devastated. Britain and France, which enjoyed prestige in international politics prior to the War, were badly undermined. The condition of post-war Europe appeared grave with shortages of food and raw materials. There was by high rates of unemployment.

The post-War material conditions challenged the laissez-faire attitude of capitalist countries. Many European countries turned into social welfare states committed to enhancing the conditions of its citizens. Not satisfied with the measures of the ruling governments the distressed masses tended to support socialist movements. This was especially so in Greece and Turkey where the communist movement was active. The USSR supported parties and movements which were left-leaning. By 1948 the Soviets had established left wing governments in the countries of eastern Europe notably in Romania, Bulgaria and Hungary. Elections held in Yugoslavia had already resulted in the formation of a communist state under Tito. As communism strengthened its grip on eastern Europe, the Americans and the British began to worry about the threat of Soviet-influenced parties coming to power in western Europe.

Emergence of a Bi-Polar World

Following the defeat of Germany, Stalin, Truman and Churchill, later replaced by Clement Attlee, met at Potsdam near Berlin in July 1945 to discuss the future of Germany. During the course of the meeting Truman informed Churchill about the invention of an atomic bomb. A few days after the conference, USA dropped atomic bombs over the Japanese cities of Hiroshima and Nagasaki. With the bombardment of Japanese cities, Japanese Emperor Hirohito announced his country's unconditional surrender. This act of bombing Japan without informing USSR created a diplomatic void between two countries. USSR produced an atomic bomb in 1949.



George Kennan

Meanwhile, difference of opinion had arisen on the creation of the World Bank and the International Monetary Fund between the US and the USSR. On 22 February 1946 George Kennan, the American charge d'affaires in Moscow, in an 8,000-word telegram to the Department of State, known as 'Long Telegram,' emphasised that the Soviet Union did not see the possibility for long-term peaceful coexistence with the capitalist world and suggested that the best strategy was to "contain" communist expansion around the globe.

In March 1946 Churchill, who was invited to speak at Fulton in Missouri, condemned the Soviet action of installing communist governments in Eastern European region. He declared "From Stettin in the Baltic to Trieste in the Adriatic, an iron curtain has descended across the continent." He called for a western alliance which would stand firm against communism. Churchill's speech is considered to signal the beginning of the Cold War. Stalin criticised Churchill as a warmonger. After the Iron Curtain Speech of Churchill, USSR continued to tighten its

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